



To suggest that the franchise was 'informed before' is not a great excuse. And 'informed before' is how much before the opening day of the tournament? **Playing for the country is paramount and comes before franchise cricket, but don't the franchises, who open not just their wallets but also their hearts to players and often their families, deserve full commitment?** It is also worth remembering that a bowler can bowl only four overs in a match, and if they have bowled a similar number of deliveries in practice without issue, what is stopping them from doing so in the game? As a bowler, you are expected to bowl 56 overs across 14 league games over two months, and, if your team reaches the final, perhaps another two or three games and 12 more overs. C'mon, for a generation that keeps talking about how fit they are, that's no load at all. Four overs in a match, that too not in one stretch, and that is too much for the body? Man, if the body is that fragile, then best to give it two more months' rest, isn't it?

The IPL has been a cash cow not

just for the overseas players but for their Boards too. Does the average Indian fan know that Cricket Boards get 10% of the fee a player from their country is bought for? It is not clear whether the BCCI or the franchise pays this commission for issuing the No Objection Certificate.

So, to put this in perspective, over the last couple of seasons, there have been 16 players from Australia bought by the different franchises for a total of Rs. 121.65 crore. There are 12 England players bought at Rs. 68 crore, and from New Zealand, another 12 players for over Rs. 33 crore; from South Africa, 17 players taking home around Rs. 71 crore. There are eight players from West Indies taking around Rs. 59 crore. Do the calculations, and each cricket Board is making a tidy sum just to issue an email saying they have no objection to their player playing in the IPL.

No other T20 league in the world, which has overseas players, pays a single dime to the Boards of the overseas players in their leagues. Not even the Hundred, which had an auction for the first time, since four

Batter only: Cricket Australia said the timeline for Cameron Green, who has not rolled his arm in nearly a year, to bowl had been "clearly outlined" to KKR ahead of the IPL season. REUTERS

out of the six teams had Indian owners, so why not milk the cash cow?

We in India love cricket and love the cricketers even more. And yes, there will be insurance for the players, so perhaps the franchise won't go out of pocket if a player does not play all the games. But surely the time has come for the franchises to get tough and demand some bang for the buck they are giving the player.

Maybe the BCCI needs to step in and, as they have done by banning overseas players for two years for pulling out after being bought at the auction, introduce something similar for players who are not available from the first game of the tournament unless they are on national duty. This will send a strong message to those who think they can take Indian cricket for granted.